History-Conditioned SAC under Sensor Faults: A Pilot Study of Adaptation and Retention

Felix Surjodinoto, Keandre Rafael, Delroy, and Samuel Philip

Computer Science Department, School of Computer Science,
Bina Nusantara University, Jakarta 11530, Indonesia
{felix.surjodinoto,keandre.rafael,delroy,samuel.philip}@binus.ac.id

Abstract. A controller that keeps learning after its sensing changes should improve under the new condition without losing what it could already do, so both outcomes must be measured. We study continued Soft Actor-Critic training of a history-conditioned transformer and a reactive controller after the onset of observation noise or a three-step observation delay in HalfCheetah-v5 and Ant-v5. Eight source checkpoints per controller and task each branch into the two faults, with or without half of each batch drawn from earlier clean experience, plus a control that continues on clean sensing. Every branch runs 20,000 steps, and the same weights are evaluated under the fault and under clean sensing. In HalfCheetah, the reactive controller improved under delay (+689) while its clean return fell (−1,390); the transformer did not improve under delay and lost clean return (−2,496). There, retained replay reduced each clean-condition loss, with all eight seeds agreeing, but shrank the reactive controller's delay gain, and an exploratory critic diagnostic shows that under delay, mixing kept the critics' values on delayed histories inflated relative to clean ones. The Ant sources learned to stand rather than walk, and the faults cost them little. Inference took 0.58 ms per action for the transformer on one CPU thread. The study reproduces an earlier three-seed pilot exactly but does not confirm its small transformer gain under delay.

Keywords: Reinforcement learning · Sensor faults · History conditioning · Retention · Experience replay

1 Introduction

An adaptive controller should learn to operate under new conditions while preserving behavior acquired earlier. These are separate requirements: a policy can improve on a new condition while deteriorating on an old one, and a training plateau is not the same as forgetting. Our long-term objective is real-time visual control in TrackMania 2020 (Fig. 1a), where training plateaus with transformer and world-model components motivated a controlled study of how interaction history and retained experience affect continued learning. Primacy bias [13], loss of plasticity [4] and forgetting during fine-tuning [18] are relevant mechanisms,

but none can be assigned to a run without measuring new-condition and old-condition performance directly. We therefore measure both.

The intervention is a change in *sensing*. A sensor fault alters what the policy observes, whereas an actuator fault alters the applied control; delayed or noisy signals change the information a policy needs [17]. History conditioning supplies past observations, actions and rewards; a transformer is one way to encode them, and Soft Actor-Critic (SAC) [8] supplies the learning objective. In-context RL uses history to adapt with fixed parameters [5,6,11]. Our question concerns *continued parameter learning*: after a trained controller encounters changed sensing, does further training improve its return, what happens to its earlier clean-condition performance, and what does mixing earlier clean experience into replay do?

We study this in HalfCheetah-v5 and Ant-v5. Eight source checkpoints per controller and task initialize a history-conditioned transformer and a reactive controller. Each checkpoint branches into two sensor faults and two replay fractions, plus a control that continues training on the clean condition. All branches receive 20,000 new interactions, and the same updated weights are evaluated on the new and the old condition. The study extends an earlier three-seed, 4,000-step pilot, whose branches it reproduces exactly; the statistical analysis was fixed before the runs.

Our contributions are (i) a behaviorally verified sensor-fault intervention for continued SAC training of history-conditioned and reactive controllers; (ii) paired adaptation and retention measurements in two environments, with a control that continues training on clean sensing and with pre-specified paired tests; (iii) a critic-level analysis of replay mixing based on held-out soft Bellman residuals and value bias; and (iv) inference-latency measurements and released code, wrappers, seeds and checkpoints. We do not propose a new algorithm or claim a solution to forgetting.

1.1 Related Work

Memory, delay and adaptation. Recurrent model-free policies are strong baselines under partial observability when carefully tuned [12]. Off-policy transformer agents for in-context and multi-task RL are studied in AMAGO and AMAGO-2 [6,7], and Algorithm Distillation learns from learning histories [11]. Signal delay degrades standard deep RL, and delay-aware state augmentation and prediction recover much of the loss [17]. We use none of these complete methods; our transformer is a small SAC encoder whose history resets each episode, so cross-episode adaptation happens only through parameter updates.

Replay and retention. CLEAR combines replay with behavioral cloning for continual RL [15], RLPD uses prior data for efficient online RL [1], and fine-tuning pre-trained RL models forgets capabilities in states the new task does not visit early, which knowledge-retention techniques mitigate [18]. Our retained replay is the simplest rehearsal: half of each batch is old clean experience, with no cloning or feature-preservation loss.

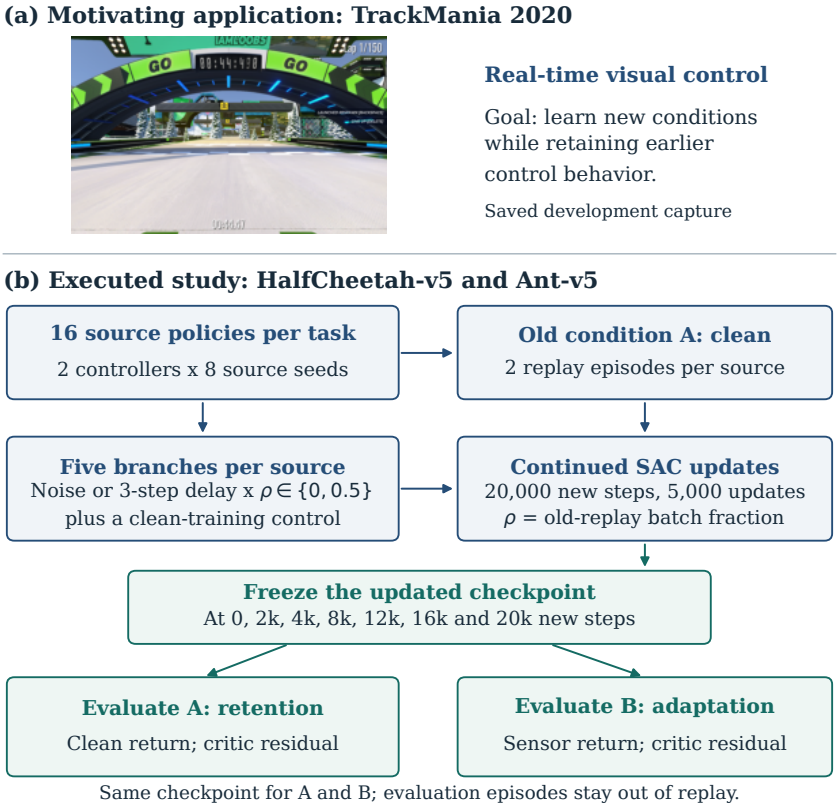


Fig. 1. Research context and workflow. (a) A TrackMania 2020 development capture from a camera-pipeline preflight; the game clock is not a benchmark lap time. (b) The executed MuJoCo procedure. Each source policy branches into five continued-training runs; old and new conditions are evaluated with the same frozen weights. All quantitative results come from panel (b).

Optimization and empirical design. The controllers use a REDQ-style critic ensemble [3]; DroQ and CrossQ show that normalization and update schedules affect efficiency [9,2]. Benchmark results with few seeds show *that* a method performed well rather than *why* [10], and empirical-design guidance calls for fixed budgets, all seeds and appropriate uncertainty [14]. We follow both by pairing outcomes with controlled contrasts and a mechanism-level critic diagnostic.

2 Method

2.1 Environments and Sensor Faults

We use the Gymnasium MuJoCo tasks [16] HalfCheetah-v5 (17 observation coordinates: 8 positions and 9 velocities; 6 actions; no termination) and Ant-v5

(27 coordinates without the 78 contact forces: 13 positions and 14 velocities; 8 actions; terminates when the torso leaves the healthy height range). Episodes last at most 1,000 steps and actions lie in $[-1, 1]$. Condition A uses true observations. Condition B alters only the sensor vector; commands and the base reward are unchanged. For noise, the policy receives

$$o_t = s_t + \epsilon_t, \qquad \epsilon_{t,j} \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_j^2), \tag{1}$$

independently across coordinates and steps, with $\sigma_j = 0.1$ for positions and 0.5 for velocities in native units, drawn from a generator separate from the simulator's reset randomness. For delay, $o_t = s_{t-3}$, with a zero vector until three earlier readings exist. Both faults start at reset and remain active.

A Gymnasium wrapper implements both faults. At each step it forwards the command unchanged to the simulator, appends the true observation to a four-element FIFO that is cleared at reset, and emits

$$x_t = [o_t, a_{t-1}, r_{t-1}, d_{t-1}] \in \mathbb{R}^{25} \text{ (HalfCheetah) or } \mathbb{R}^{37} \text{ (Ant)}, \tag{2}$$

where a_{t-1}, r_{t-1} and the termination flag d_{t-1} keep their correct timing and are zero at reset. True readings are logged for audits only. Under delay, s_t is in principle recoverable from $o_t = s_{t-3}$ and the last three commands, because the dynamics are deterministic [17]; a policy that sees only x_t has a_{t-1} but not a_{t-3} and a_{t-2}.

2.2 Controllers and History Conditioning

Table 1 summarizes both controllers. The transformer receives the most recent at most 32 tokens of the current episode. Each token passes through a two-layer embedding (Linear, LayerNorm, GELU, Linear; 64 features) plus a learned absolute position embedding, then two pre-norm causal transformer blocks. The output at the newest token, h_t, and an 8-dimensional linear projection z_t of it form the 72-dimensional feature used by the actor and by every critic. The context resets at each episode, is recomputed at every step without caching, and carries no information across episodes; only parameter updates do. The reactive controller maps the single token x_t directly to its actor and critics. It therefore sees the previous command and reward but cannot integrate a sequence. The controllers differ in capacity and preprocessing as well as memory, so comparisons between them are controller comparisons, not isolated causal estimates of memory.

The source models for each task are validation-selected checkpoints of training seeds 42–49 from one SAC recipe: 100 iterations, each collecting four episodes under randomly sampled *actuator* perturbations (action scaling and action noise) and then performing 100 actor and temperature updates, each preceded by ten critic-ensemble updates (at most 400,000 steps; 100,000 critic and 10,000 actor updates). Transformer batches hold 64 sequences of 24 steps whose first 8 steps only build context; reactive batches hold 64 transitions. The transformer recipe adds a fault-classification loss (weight 0.05) whose head is unused here. No source trained with sensor faults.

Table 1. Controller architectures (HalfCheetah sizes; Ant differs only in input and action width). Parameters exclude target networks.

Component	Transformer / reactive	Parameters
Encoder	2 causal blocks, 2 heads, width 64, FF 128, $\leq$32 tokens, linear z_t head / none	81,736 / 0
Actor	$[h_t, z_t] \to 2\times128$ / $x_t \to 2\times256$; tanh-Gaussian	27,404 / 75,532
Critics	10 heads, 2×256 with LayerNorm, on $[h_t, z_t, a]$ / $[x_t, a]$	872,970 / 752,650

2.3 Continued Training, Retained Replay and Control

For each source model, two deterministic clean episodes form a fixed old pool shared by its branches and disjoint from evaluation. Each source model then initializes five branches: noise or delay crossed with old-replay fraction $\rho \in \{0, 0.5\}$, and a control that continues training on A with $\rho = 0$. The control measures the change caused by continued optimization alone. Each branch collects 20,000 steps with its stochastic policy and performs 0.25 critic-ensemble and actor updates per step (5,000 each) on batches of 64 transitions: all new for $\rho = 0$, or 32 old and 32 new for $\rho = 0.5$. Collection is step-budgeted, so terminated Ant episodes restart and episodes are cut at evaluation budgets (as time-limit truncations); replay draws episodes in proportion to their length. Paired branches share their adaptation seed and reset schedule. Optimizers and the entropy temperature are re-initialized identically because they were not stored with the sources.

The critic target is $y = r + \gamma(1-d)\big(\min_{j\in S} \bar{Q}_j(h', a') - \alpha \log \pi(a'|h')\big)$ with $a' \sim \pi(\cdot|h')$, S two random critics of ten and $\gamma = 0.99$; critic losses are summed over the ensemble. The actor minimizes $\alpha \log \pi - \min(Q_1, Q_2)$ on detached transformer features, so the representation learns through critic regression. Target networks use Polyak retention 0.995 and dropout is disabled throughout. Each transformer sample trains its final valid transition with the exact rolling history that produced it; one quarter of samples come from the first 32 steps of an episode, so short contexts are represented. Table 2 lists the settings.

2.4 Measurements and Statistical Analysis

At each budget n, the same checkpoint is evaluated on A and B with frozen parameters, a fresh context per episode and five fixed environment seeds that never enter replay. For source seed i, fault c and fraction ρ, the new-condition change is $\Delta^B(n) = R^B(n) - R^B(0)$ and the retention change is $\Delta^A(n) = R^A(n) - R^A(0)$, where R is the mean evaluation return. A negative Δ^A is a loss of measured clean performance. Checkpoints are fixed by budget; no outcome selects them.

The replication unit is the source seed ($n = 8$); evaluation episodes are averaged within a seed first, and branches from one source model are not independent. The analysis was fixed before the runs. The primary family is the paired replay effect $D_i = \text{metric}_i(\rho{=}0.5) - \text{metric}_i(\rho{=}0)$ for Δ^A and Δ^B at 20,000

Table 2. Continued-training configuration (both tasks). Budgets exclude source training.

Setting	Value
Source seeds per controller and task	8 (42–49)
Branches per source model	noise/delay $\times$ $\rho \in \{0, 0.5\}$, clean control
New-condition steps; updates per branch	20,000; 5,000
Clean replay pool per source model	2 episodes
Batch size; ensemble critics	64; 10
Actor / critic / temperature learning rates	10^{-4} / 10^{-4} / 3×10^{-4}
Initial temperature; target entropy	0.1; $-\lvert\mathcal{A}\rvert$
Discount; target retention; gradient clip	0.99; 0.995; 10
Evaluation budgets (steps)	0, 2k, 4k, 8k, 12k, 16k, 20k
Evaluation episodes per condition and budget	5 deterministic, fixed seeds

steps, for each controller and fault (eight tests per task), using exact two-sided Wilcoxon signed-rank tests with Holm correction. We report mean differences with 95% t intervals and seed-bootstrap intervals (10,000 resamples). A secondary family tests fault-specific forgetting, Δ^A of each $\rho = 0$ fault branch minus Δ^A of the clean control (four tests per task); per-arm changes are tested against zero in the released analysis files. With eight seeds the smallest attainable exact p is 0.0078, so a Holm-adjusted p cannot fall below 0.0625 in the eight-test primary family or below 0.031 in the four-test family. This floor follows from the pre-specified design, and we report it rather than change the correction after the runs: conclusions about the replay effect rest on the interval estimates and on sign agreement across seeds, and non-significance is not evidence of equivalence.

2.5 Critic Diagnostic for Replay Mixing

With fraction ρ, the critic regresses onto targets drawn from the mixture $(1-\rho)\mathcal{D}_B + \rho\mathcal{D}_A$. Two distortions are possible. Old transitions were generated by the source policy, so their targets rely on the current actor's actions in histories it is not being trained to act in (an off-policy mismatch). Moreover, a history can occur under both sensing channels while implying different states, especially under delay; its regression target is then a ρ-weighted blend of two Bellman targets, biasing the fitted value for both. To measure these effects, we evaluate each saved checkpoint's critics on its own held-out evaluation trajectories from A and B. We report the root-mean-square soft Bellman residual $y - \frac{1}{10}\sum_j Q_j(h,a)$, computed with the training target and the saved temperature, averaging over all critic pairs, and the Monte-Carlo bias $Q - G_t$ for steps with a complete discounted return G_t. The critics estimate the soft value of the stochastic policy whereas G_t is the deterministic policy's return. This offset is shared by the A and B data of one checkpoint, so instead of raw biases we compare the value-bias gap, the bias on B data minus that on A data.

2.6 Verification, Latency and Reproducibility

Twelve behavioral tests check corruption, timing, random-stream separation, replay boundaries, masking, parameter updates and positional support. A real MuJoCo test applies identical commands under clean, noisy and delayed sensing and requires identical states and rewards. Every run snapshots its source files, protocol, package versions and checkpoint hashes, and records commands, model inputs, audit-only true readings and rewards for every evaluation. We measure inference latency of the deployment call (a full 32-token forward pass for the transformer) at batch size one with real model inputs, excluding simulation, on CPU with one and four threads and on GPU. Runs use Python 3.12.10, PyTorch 2.11.0 with CUDA 12.8, Gymnasium 1.3.0 and MuJoCo 3.12.0 on Windows with an NVIDIA GeForce RTX 5070 Laptop GPU; rollouts infer on CPU and updates run on GPU.

3 Results

3.1 Reproducibility and Executed Budgets

All 80 HalfCheetah and 80 Ant branches ran exactly 20,000 steps and 5,000 updates. The 24 HalfCheetah branches that share their seeds with the pilot reproduce its returns at 0, 2,000 and 4,000 steps exactly (largest absolute difference 0.000), and recomputing the pilot's metric from them returns its published means. After a memory failure, 9 completed reactive branches were rerun from scratch; their evaluation returns and 9 of 9 final checkpoints are bit-identical to the first run.

3.2 HalfCheetah

Table 3 lists the outcomes and Fig. 2 (top rows) shows their course. Before continued training, noise reduced the mean return of the transformer sources from 2,695 to 2,402 and that of the reactive sources from 3,239 to 2,900, whereas delay reduced it to 13 and −179. Continued clean training raised clean return by +782 and +963, with every seed improving. The sources were therefore not converged, and the clean control, not $\Delta^A = 0$, is the reference for fault-specific forgetting.

Adaptation. Under delay, the reactive controller's delayed-sensing return rose by +689 [373, 1,006] with every seed improving, to 510, still far below its clean return. The transformer did not improve under delay (−115 [−259, 28]). Under noise, both controllers first lost return. The transformer recovered to +89 [−163, 341] by 20,000 steps, whereas the reactive controller stayed below its starting value (−443 [−546, −339], all seeds).

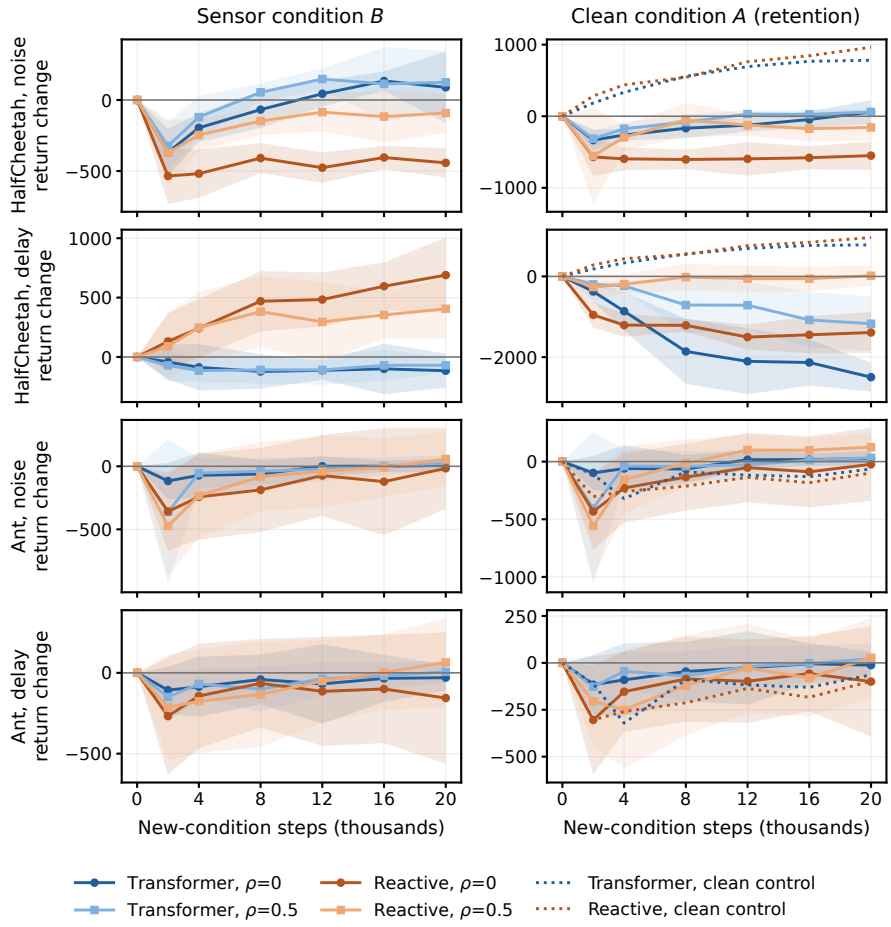


Fig. 2. Mean change in sensor-condition return (left) and clean-condition return (right) during continued training in HalfCheetah (top two rows) and Ant (bottom two rows), with 95% t intervals over eight source seeds. Dotted lines are the clean-continuation controls.

Retention. Without retained replay, every fault branch ended below the clean control on clean data. The differences are −723 under noise and −3,278 under delay for the transformer, and −1,514 and −2,353 for the reactive controller. All eight seeds agree in each case (Holm-adjusted $p = 0.0312$, the floor of this family). Relative to the sources, clean return fell under delay (−2,496 and −1,390) and, for the reactive controller, under noise (−550). The transformer's clean return under noise ended near its starting value (+59 [−104, 222]).

Retained replay. Retained replay reduced each clean-condition loss (Table 4). The paired effect on Δ^A was $D = +1{,}323$ for the transformer under delay, and

Table 3. Outcomes at 20,000 steps: mean over eight source seeds with 95% t intervals. $B(0)$ is the zero-step sensor-condition return; ΔB and ΔA are the changes in sensor- and clean-condition return. For the clean control, $B = A$.

Controller	Fault	ρ	$B(0)$	ΔB [95% CI]	ΔA [95% CI]
HalfCheetah-v5					
Transformer	Noise	0	2,402	+89 [−163, 341]	+59 [−104, 222]
Transformer	Noise	0.5	2,402	+125 [−96, 346]	+59 [14, 104]
Transformer	Delay	0	13	−115 [−259, 28]	−2,496 [−2,852, −2,139]
Transformer	Delay	0.5	13	−69 [−130, −9]	−1,173 [−1,846, −500]
Transformer	Clean control	0	2,695	—	+782 [606, 958]
Reactive	Noise	0	2,900	−443 [−546, −339]	−550 [−748, −352]
Reactive	Noise	0.5	2,900	−91 [−230, 47]	−157 [−339, 26]
Reactive	Delay	0	−179	+689 [373, 1,006]	−1,390 [−1,896, −884]
Reactive	Delay	0.5	−179	+406 [153, 658]	+16 [−233, 266]
Reactive	Clean control	0	3,239	—	+963 [740, 1,187]
Ant-v5					
Transformer	Noise	0	921	+7 [−46, 61]	+27 [−37, 90]
Transformer	Noise	0.5	921	+22 [−40, 85]	+34 [−38, 105]
Transformer	Delay	0	918	−30 [−110, 50]	−12 [−83, 59]
Transformer	Delay	0.5	918	+6 [−60, 72]	+22 [−58, 102]
Transformer	Clean control	0	899	—	−64 [−187, 60]
Reactive	Noise	0	651	−16 [−338, 305]	−24 [−341, 293]
Reactive	Noise	0.5	651	+57 [−159, 274]	+125 [1, 250]
Reactive	Delay	0	588	−156 [−562, 251]	−100 [−393, 194]
Reactive	Delay	0.5	588	+64 [−211, 339]	+27 [−185, 239]
Reactive	Clean control	0	674	—	−98 [−376, 180]

$D = +1{,}406$ and $D = +394$ for the reactive controller under delay and noise, with all eight seeds positive in each case. With $\rho = 0.5$, the reactive controller's clean return under delay ended at its source value (+16 [−233, 266]), and its noise-condition decline also shrank ($D = +351$, all seeds). The cost appeared under delay. Replay reduced the reactive controller's delayed-sensing gain ($D = -284$, [−567, −1]; 6 of 8 seeds negative), the trade-off seen in the pilot. For the transformer, replay left the delayed-sensing outcome unchanged ($D = +46$, [−102, 195]) and changed neither outcome under noise. Each consistent effect has exact $p = 0.0078$ and Holm-adjusted $p = 0.0625$, the floor for eight tests with eight seeds.

Comparison with the pilot. The three-seed pilot had shown a small transformer gain under delay after 4,000 steps (+98). With eight seeds and five evaluation episodes, the change at that budget is −87 (6 of 8 seeds negative), and it remains negative through 20,000 steps. The reactive controller's delay gain and both controllers' clean-condition losses under delay persist and grow with the longer budget.

3.3 Ant

Sources. Under the same recipe, every Ant source learned to stand rather than walk. Across the 16 sources, the mean forward velocity in clean evaluation never exceeded 0.007 m/s in magnitude, every clean evaluation episode lasted 1,000 steps, and the source returns (899 for the transformer and 674 for the reactive

Table 4. Pre-specified paired replay effect $D = \text{metric}(\rho{=}0.5) - \text{metric}(\rho{=}0)$ at 20,000 steps (eight seeds). Holm-adjusted exact Wilcoxon p within each task's eight tests; +/− counts seeds with positive and negative D.

Controller	Fault	$D_{\Delta A}$ [95% CI]	p_{Holm}	+/−	$D_{\Delta B}$ [95% CI]	p_{Holm}	+/−
HalfCheetah-v5							
Transformer	Noise	0 [−158, 159]	1.00	5/3	+36 [−63, 134]	1.00	5/3
Transformer	Delay	+1,323 [595, 2,050]	0.0625	8/0	+46 [−102, 195]	1.00	5/3
Reactive	Noise	+394 [188, 599]	0.0625	8/0	+351 [153, 549]	0.0625	8/0
Reactive	Delay	+1,406 [816, 1,997]	0.0625	8/0	−284 [−567, −1]	0.31	2/6
Ant-v5							
Transformer	Noise	+7 [−21, 35]	1.00	4/4	+15 [−3, 32]	0.55	6/2
Transformer	Delay	+34 [−27, 96]	1.00	4/4	+36 [−31, 103]	1.00	5/3
Reactive	Noise	+149 [−116, 414]	1.00	6/2	+74 [−135, 282]	1.00	5/3
Reactive	Delay	+127 [−61, 315]	1.00	5/3	+220 [−34, 474]	0.31	7/1

controller) come mainly from Ant's healthy reward of one per step. Standing proved robust to the faults. Zero-step sensor-condition returns were 921 under noise and 918 under delay for the transformer, and 651 and 588 for the reactive controller, whose delayed-sensing episodes ended early in 12% of evaluations. Ant therefore tests retention during continued training more than adaptation.

Continued training. In every arm, mean return on both conditions fell during the first 2,000 steps (Fig. 2, bottom rows), including the clean controls (−111 and −304), and then recovered partly or fully. Because the clean controls dipped as well, this transient comes from restarting training rather than from the faults; in HalfCheetah, the clean controls improved at every budget. At 20,000 steps, every 95% interval for the change in sensor-condition return included zero (Table 3). Continued clean training did not improve the standing sources: clean return changed by −64 [−187, 60] for the transformer and −98 [−376, 180] for the reactive controller. The fault-specific contrasts, all negative in HalfCheetah, were therefore positive or near zero. The transformer's noise branches ended above the clean control on clean data by +90 [21, 159], with all eight seeds agreeing (Holm-adjusted $p = 0.0312$, the floor); the other three intervals included zero.

Retained replay. All eight paired replay effects had positive means, but every t interval included zero (Table 4). The most consistent was the effect on the reactive controller's delayed-sensing return ($D = +220$, [−34, 474]; 7 of 8 seeds positive; Holm-adjusted $p = 0.31$). Without replay, that return changed by −156 and 30% of delayed-sensing episodes ended early at 20,000 steps; with replay, 10% did. This effect has the opposite sign to HalfCheetah's, where replay reduced the delayed-sensing gain. With replay, the reactive controller's clean return under noise rose by +125 [1, 250], with all eight seeds improving.

3.4 Critic Diagnostic

Table 5 reports the diagnostic, which is not part of the pre-specified analysis; the value-bias gap is exploratory. At the HalfCheetah sources, the held-out soft

Table 5. Critic diagnostic (mean over eight seeds) at the source checkpoint and after 20,000 steps with $\rho = 0$ or 0.5: root-mean-square held-out soft Bellman residual on clean (A) and corrupted (B) evaluation data, and the value-bias gap, the Monte-Carlo bias on B data minus that on A data of the same checkpoint (positive: values on corrupted data are overestimated relative to clean data; exploratory).

		Residual, clean data A			Residual, corrupted data B			Value-bias gap $B - A$		
Controller	Fault	Source	ρ=0	ρ=0.5	Source	ρ=0	ρ=0.5	Source	ρ=0	ρ=0.5
HalfCheetah-v5										
Transformer	Noise	0.58	0.58	0.61	4.25	1.13	1.49	+27	+18	+13
Transformer	Delay	0.58	1.61	2.87	4.36	0.96	1.38	+171	+27	+89
Reactive	Noise	1.55	1.04	1.72	6.89	1.81	3.40	+28	+19	+23
Reactive	Delay	1.55	3.07	2.73	5.84	1.91	3.61	+268	+114	+204
Ant-v5										
Transformer	Noise	2.16	0.23	0.30	3.48	0.44	0.58	−2	0	−2
Transformer	Delay	2.16	1.35	0.34	1.16	0.27	0.28	−1	0	−1
Reactive	Noise	1.06	0.28	0.22	5.56	1.00	0.97	+2	+2	+8
Reactive	Delay	1.06	0.72	3.05	2.00	3.03	1.23	0	+15	+3

Table 6. Per-action inference latency (ms) of the HalfCheetah source controllers (seed 42), batch size one, real model inputs, simulation excluded; 10,000 timed steps after warm-up on an AMD Ryzen 9 8940HX CPU and a GeForce RTX 5070 Laptop GPU. The transformer recomputes its full 32-token context at every step.

Controller	Device	Mean	p95	p99	Max
Transformer	CPU, 1 thread	0.58	0.62	0.66	1.56
Transformer	CPU, 4 threads	0.58	0.62	0.73	1.46
Transformer	GPU	1.64	1.72	1.79	3.03
Reactive	CPU, 1 thread	0.09	0.11	0.13	0.53
Reactive	CPU, 4 threads	0.09	0.11	0.13	0.48
Reactive	GPU	0.48	0.53	0.56	0.94

Bellman residual on corrupted data was several times that on clean data, and continued training on corrupted data reduced it in every arm. Retained replay raised the reactive controller's residual on corrupted data under both faults (by +1.59 under noise and +1.69 under delay, all eight seeds each; Holm-adjusted $p = 0.0625$, the floor) and its clean-data residual under noise (+0.68, all seeds). For the transformer, only the increase on noisy data had an interval excluding zero (+0.36 [0.02, 0.69]). In Ant, replay raised neither residual consistently; it lowered the transformer's clean-data residual under delay (−1.01, all eight seeds).

The value-bias gap separates the faults. The HalfCheetah source critics overvalued delayed-sensing histories relative to clean ones by +171 (transformer) and +268 (reactive), with all eight seeds positive in both, against +27 and +28 under noise. Training on delayed data alone shrank this gap to +27 and +114. With retained replay it stayed larger, at +89 and +204: paired effects of +62 [16, 109] and +90 [41, 139] (7 and 7 of 8 seeds positive). Under noise, replay changed the gap by only −6 (transformer) and +4 (reactive). In Ant, every mean gap stayed within 16 return units of zero.

3.5 Inference Latency

Table 6 lists the per-action latency. On one CPU thread the transformer took 0.58 ms on average and 0.66 ms at the 99th percentile, and no timed CPU call exceeded 1.56 ms. Every CPU call therefore fit the 2 ms period of 500 Hz control, and the 10 ms period of 100 Hz control by a wide margin; the reactive controller took 0.09 ms. Four threads brought no gain. At batch size one the GPU was slower than the CPU (1.64 ms mean and 3.03 ms maximum for the transformer), consistent with per-call launch and transfer overhead dominating such small networks. The figures cover the network call on a laptop workstation, not a complete control loop or an embedded processor.

4 Discussion

Adaptation and retention are separate outcomes. Measuring both on the same checkpoints separates patterns that a single score would merge. Under delay in HalfCheetah, the reactive controller adapted and lost clean performance; retained replay preserved its clean performance and kept part of the gain. The transformer lost clean performance without adapting. Under noise, the transformer kept both returns near their starting values, whereas the reactive controller lost both, far less so when half of each batch came from earlier clean experience. In HalfCheetah, every fault branch without replay also forfeited the improvement that continued clean training produced, so a branch that merely holds its starting return has still fallen behind. Ant shows the control's value in the other direction: its standing sources lost little to either fault and did not improve under clean training, so changes in its fault branches reflect continued training more than the faults.

Why the controllers differ. The information available to each controller predicts an advantage for the transformer under both faults. Its context holds the last three commands needed to reconstruct the current state from the delayed reading, and a window of noisy readings that it could average; the reactive token holds one reading and the previous command. In HalfCheetah, the noise results agree with this prediction, but the delay results contradict it: only the reactive controller improved. We see four candidate explanations, none tested here. First, compensating for the delay requires the encoder to learn a new computation, and it learns only through critic regression, because the actor uses detached features. Second, continued training is relatively weaker for the transformer: each update trains 64 transitions, a sixteenth of the 1,024 per critic update in its source training, whereas the reactive controller trains on 64 transitions in both phases. Third, 5,000 updates at learning rate 10^{-4} may be too few to reorganize a representation that is adequate for clean sensing. Fourth, the controllers differ in capacity and initial returns (Table 1). Separating these explanations requires matched ablations, such as a transformer restricted to one token or a reactive controller given stacked readings and commands.

Replay mixing. Of the sixteen paired replay effects in the two tasks, only one had a negative mean: the HalfCheetah reactive controller's smaller delayed-sensing gain. The critic diagnostic is consistent with the target blending described in Sec. 2.5. The source critics overvalued delayed histories relative to clean ones, anticipating only part of the return that the source policies lost under delay. Training on delayed data alone removed most of this value-bias gap; with clean experience mixed in, the gap stayed larger, and the reactive controller's residual on delayed data stayed higher. The transformer showed the same gap pattern but had no delayed-sensing gain to lose. Under noise, replay improved both of the reactive controller's returns while raising its residuals, so a larger held-out residual alone does not indicate a worse policy. In Ant, where the faults barely mattered, the gaps stayed near zero. A two-episode clean pool is a minimal form of rehearsal. In HalfCheetah, retained replay did not match the clean control's gains on clean data, and behavior-cloning or feature-preservation terms [15,18] could act differently.

Limitations. The sources were trained with actuator perturbations and then warm-started; sources trained to convergence, or with sensor faults, may behave differently. The Ant sources stood rather than walked, so Ant tests the retention of a posture rather than of locomotion; we did not tune the source recipe after seeing this. Twenty thousand steps are 5% of the source recipe's 400,000-step budget, and 5,000 updates are 5% of its critic updates, so slower adaptation could still occur. We used one severity per fault, one learning-rate setting and two replay fractions, without tuning. Humanoid-v5 was not run: SAC's reported Humanoid learning curves span millions of steps [8], far beyond the 400,000-step source recipe, and our single workstation was at its memory limit. With eight seeds, exact tests cannot reach a family-wise 0.05 level in the primary family, so we rely on interval estimates. The critic diagnostic lies outside the pre-specified analysis, and the value-bias gap is exploratory. Evaluations use five deterministic episodes per condition and budget, and the controllers' differences in capacity prevent attributing their contrast to memory alone.

5 Conclusion

We measured adaptation and retention during continued SAC training under sensor faults, with eight seeds per controller, two tasks, a clean-continuation control and pre-specified paired tests. In HalfCheetah, delay separated the two outcomes: the reactive controller adapted while losing clean performance, and the transformer lost clean performance without adapting. Retaining half a batch of earlier clean experience reduced every clean-condition loss, at the cost of part of the reactive controller's delay gain, and the critic diagnostic is consistent with values blended across the two sensing channels. In Ant, standing sources tolerated both faults, so that task probed continued training more than adaptation. Next steps are matched ablations that separate memory from capacity, explicit retention objectives, and source recipes that produce locomotion.

Code and data availability. Code, sensor-fault wrappers, seed and launch scripts, frozen protocols, analysis scripts, evaluation records and source and adapted checkpoints: **[repository URL pending]**.

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AI Usage Declaration

Google Antigravity with a Gemini model assisted implementation of earlier research architecture and algorithms. OpenAI Codex assisted the submitted version: manuscript restructuring, primary-source lookup, formatting, code inspection, implementation and testing of the sensor-fault pilot, experiment orchestration, result verification, and analysis and plotting scripts. Claude Code (Anthropic) assisted the camera-ready revision: extending the experiment runner to more seeds, longer budgets, the clean control and Ant-v5; statistical, critic-diagnostic and latency scripts; experiment orchestration; reference verification; and manuscript revision. All observations were generated by executed simulator runs, and tables and result plots are computed from saved run records. The workflow diagram summarizes the implemented procedure, and its TrackMania panel is a saved development screenshot. Generative AI was not used to invent experimental observations or references. The authors remain responsible for the implementation, verification, analysis, interpretation and final manuscript.

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